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Department of Design

Mental Health and Wellbeing Practices in Design Education: A Call for Action

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Abstract

Alarming numbers of university design students are experiencing significant issues related to their mental health and wellbeing. While the conditions affecting their mental health are systemic, universities play a key role in addressing academic-related factors. This paper aims to better understand the stressors impacting design students' wellbeing and identify strategies for addressing them. It reviews general academic and design-specific stressors highlighted in the literature. Drawing from a small sample of European design schools, the paper also shares promising practices for addressing these stressors. Kick-starting cross-institutional sharing, it offers a starting point for further collective efforts to improve student wellbeing.

Keywords: mental health, wellbeing, students, design education

Introduction

During SERVDES2023, we, the authors of this paper, connected over our growing concern for the mental wellbeing of our design students. We have been meeting regularly ever since to mobilize around an appropriate response. Studies have long highlighted that university students experience mental health issues at greater rates than the general population (Ibrahim et al., 2013), worsen by COVID-19 impact (Lederer et al., 2021). In addition, university design programs demonstrate an increased likelihood of mental health challenges compared to students in other disciplines (Lipson et al., 2016). Scholars highlight numerous stressors that design students face, including high levels of ambiguity and insecurity about professional identity (Price, 2023; 2024; Price & van der Bilj-Brouwer, 2023).

While some research explores university educators' roles in fostering design students' resilience (e.g., Price, 2021; Price & van der Bijl-Brouwer, 2023), there is no comprehensive overview of strategies used across design universities to support student wellbeing or their effectiveness in addressing key stressors. Without any kind of state-of-the-art review, universities and educators, like us, struggle to take strategic action. This paper examines everyday stressors affecting design students, reviews existing university initiatives, and identifies promising practices. Drawing from a small sample of European design programs, it also highlights opportunities for further development and calls for a collective movement to enhance student wellbeing.

After briefly framing the current youth mental health landscape and the role of schools, we review the stressors faced by university design students based on extant literature. We then outline our analysis approach and share exemplary strategies from six design schools. Finally, we discuss gaps, opportunities, and a broader call to action.

Youth Mental Health and the Role of Schools

In 2019, an estimated 14 million young individuals were reported to be dealing with mental health challenges (European Council, 2024). Mental health problems among young people are a great public health burden affecting around 10–20% of children and adolescents worldwide (Signorini et al., 2017), with onset often occurring during early adolescence. In addition, many adolescents experience poor mental health despite the absence of mental illness (Bell et al., 2019), resonating with the World Health Organization's (WHO, 2022) broader concept of mental health as going beyond the absence of mental disease or infirmity.

The recent entanglement of nested crises has contributed to the worsening of mental health in children and adolescents (Bell et al., 2023; Kauhanen et al., 2023). In this context, schools are critical for mental health promotion and support (Cefai et al., 2021). This is not necessarily a settled belief, particularly in university settings where young adults are trained toward job placements and conflicting views on the role of education and teachers might coexist: one focusing on economic production and the other on students' ability to live well or flourish (Curren et al., 2024).

Stressors Affecting Design Student Mental Health and Wellbeing

General stressors impacting mental health and wellbeing

Emerging adulthood, which coincides with higher education, is a critical developmental stage characterized by significant changes in independence, responsibility, and self-direction (Arnett et al., 2014) that can impact students' mental health and academic engagement.

The mental wellbeing of university students is shaped by a complex interplay of factors that evolve. Limone & Toto (2022) identify these factors across multiple domains, including academic, social, lifestyle, psychological, and physiobiological. Academic stressors encompass various challenges, from adjusting to new academic and social environments during the transition to university to concerns about career uncertainty and future employability. These transitions can elevate stress and anxiety as students navigate unfamiliar academic and social expectations (Briggs et al., 2020) and may contribute to depressive symptoms (Pisarik et al., 2017). Additionally,

academic pressures, competitive and multicultural learning environments, and demanding workloads with tight deadlines can exacerbate stress, fatigue, cognitive overload, and burnout (e.g., Pascoe et al., 2020).

Although this study primarily examines academic stressors, it is essential to recognize their intersection with broader life challenges (Sheldon et al., 2021; Hyseni Duraku et al., 2024). Understanding these overlapping stressors is essential for developing holistic strategies to support students throughout their journey.

Design-specific stressors influencing mental health and wellbeing

Design involves negotiating uncertainty and ambiguity. Processual uncertainty in design stems from unique theoretical markers; no one correct solution is deducible (Simon, 1996), problems and solutions co-evolve (Dorst, 2011), and the value of proposed solutions is always contestable (Liedtka, 2015). Due to these nuances, design pedagogy draws from problem-based learning and transformative learning to encourage exploration, creativity, and pluralism. In ideal circumstances, design education has transformative potential, producing students with the capabilities, knowledge, and skills to bring about important societal changes and a positive impact.

The theoretical markers of the design process shape a set of practices that can potentially induce stress (Price, 2023, 2024; Tracey & Hutchinson, 2018). The design process offers little comfort to perfectionists, nor does it reward those prone to staying in an analytical state. Plural ideas are underpinned by plural values, and so designing evokes tension between stakeholders and teams as to what should be designed and why. When ideas are developed into concepts and presented, the designer may face harsh, prejudicial, or cynical feedback as they challenge prevailing standards. The experience of designing can shock new students to design, especially those from secondary school education systems where delivering one ‘right’ answer has become a trained behaviour.

Furthermore, considerations of systemic design and a pursuit of higher impact, combined with evidence of the climate crisis, provide a backdrop to concerning statistical rates of student mental health deficiency and alerts about wellbeing. Given that the general academic stressors remain, it is time for action in higher education. Table 1 outlines academic stressors, followed by design-specific ones.

Stressors	Description	References
General academic stressors		
Transition to university	Students moving from secondary to higher education are exposed to new cultures, heavier academic workloads, new social relationships and environments, and, for many, new financial responsibilities and/or relocating to a different city/country/continent.	Briggs et al. (2012); Beiter et al. (2015)
Academic performance	High academic demands contribute to students' stress and anxiety levels. Poor academic performance is often linked to low self-esteem and depressive symptoms.	Pascoe et al. (2020); Limone & Toto (2022)
Perceived workload	A high students' subjective assessment of the amount and difficulty of their academic tasks is associated with increased stress and lowered overall wellbeing.	Kember & Leung (2006); Kyndt et al. (2014); Rummell (2015)
Classroom competition	When students perceive a high level of competition in their classes, they face an increased risk of experiencing anxiety and depression.	Posselt & Lipson (2016); Van den Bergh et al. (2022)
Career uncertainty/ Career anxiety	Career uncertainty can contribute to stress, anxiety, and depressive symptoms.	Pisarik et al. (2017); Boo et al. (2022)
Study-Work-Life balance	Struggles with study-work-life balance increase stress levels, reduce academic engagement, and negatively impact overall wellbeing.	Creed et al. (2015); Curtis & Shani (2002)
Multicultural university environment	Cultural adaptation stress can reduce student confidence and participation, hindering collaboration and social integration.	Lantz-Deaton (2017)
Design-specific stressors		
Problem solution co-evolution	The problem-solution co-evolution can cause paralysis, a lack of confidence, and not knowing what to do or when to stop.	Tracey & Hutchinson (2018)

Cognitive demands inherent in art and design disciplines	Art and Design favour intuition, subjectivity, and emotion linked to higher emotional dysregulation compared to fields that prioritize logic, objectivity, and structured forms of expression.	Lipson et al. (2016)
Interpersonal conflict with project team members	Design allows for a plural dialogue between team members regarding what the future ought to be. Conflict can arise about what, why, and how to design.	Price (2024)
Dealing with criticism, public scrutiny, and ethical concerns when working for and with clients	Dealing with criticism and public scrutiny when challenging the status quo, naivety about the hostility of institutions. Also, difficulties collaborating with clients.	Price (2021); Price & van der Bilj-Brouwer (2023); Price (2024)
Feeling powerless in the face of systemic problems	Attentive to wicked societal problems and aiming to support societal changes. Feel responsible but also insecure and powerless regarding the impact of their designs.	Price (2022); Price & van der Bijl-Brouwer (2023); van den Bergh et al. (2022)
Insecurity of dealing with a vulnerable population	Worries about and unprepared to work with vulnerable people; also, going through the emotional burden of empathizing with their experiences.	Price & van der Bijl-Brouwer (2023)
Uncertain and fluid professional identity	A designer's identity must remain flexible and dynamic, reflecting the evolving nature of design and the fluid role of a designer.	Baha et al. (2020); Price & van der Bilj-Brouwer (2023)
Communication barriers. Adaptation to a new creative environment. Cultural Intelligence	Communication barriers affect knowledge sharing and expressive ties negatively during the initial stages of teamwork in creative fields. Students must operate effectively within a disciplinary context in a socially diverse global environment.	Chen & Agarwal (2017) Zhong et al. (2020) Peng & Keuh (2022)

Table 1. General and design-specific mental health and wellbeing stressors for higher education students.

Introduction to our university network

Following the 2023 ServDes conference in Rio de Janeiro, a network of university design schools—including Politecnico di Milano, Aalto University, Aalborg University, University of Arts London, Delft University of Technology, and Oslo School of Architecture and Design—was formed to address student mental health challenges. These institutions, all offering Master's programs in Service Design, are committed to integrating wellbeing into teaching. While representing a small sample from the Global North, the network provides valuable insights into the challenges faced by design students and potential interventions beyond university-level psychological support. Table 2 summarizes key university and program characteristics and mental health and wellbeing data at the national and university level.

Country	University Description	National & University Data on Mental Health and Wellbeing
Italy	**Politecnico di Milano**, **School of Design** is today the largest international university for training product, communication, interior, interaction, and fashion designers, with about 4300 students and over 450 lecturers. The Master's Degree Program in Product-Service System Design (PSSD) focuses on systems that combine products, services, spaces, and digital technologies to address complex challenges sustainably. 80 students are enrolled every year.	Multiple studies confirm: - A higher prevalence of psychological distress among Italian university students compared to the same age population (Porru et al., 2021). - The need for systematic mental health prevention and support services (Caldarelli et al., 2024). - Older students access University Counseling Services later due to delayed adulthood transition, stigma, and low help-seeking (Bosco et al., 2019). At Politecnico di Milano, demand for psychological support tripled from 2019 to 2021 and continues to rise.

Finland	**Aalto University, School of Arts, Design and Architecture (ARTS)** is a Nordic higher education leader specializing in design, fashion, architecture, film, and fine arts, fostering research and innovation. The Collaborative and Industrial Design major within the Master's of Design program extends industrial design into interaction, service, and social design, equipping students with empathic, strategic, and technical skills. Approximately 35 to 40 students participate in the CoID master's program each year.	The Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare survey shows: - In 2021, one-third of university students had reasons to suspect a mental health disorder. - In 2024, the psychological burden among higher education students decreased to 29%, down from 35% in 2021 (KOTT, 2024). The Aalto University Wellbeing Survey (2023) reports on students' burnout risk: - 46% in the School of Arts, Design and Architecture, 40% in the Business School, and 42% in the School of Engineering.
The Netherlands	**Delft University of Technology (TU Delft)** is the oldest, largest, and most comprehensive university of technology in the Netherlands, educating over 27.000 students, with 6.500 staff. The Faculty of Industrial Design Engineering is one of the oldest and largest multidisciplinary product and service design-oriented research and education institutions in the world. Three MSc programmes, Integrated Product Design, Design for Interaction, and Strategic Product Design, host an annual combined intake of approximately 450 students.	The National 2023 Caring Universities survey found: - Among 9,048 students, 30.4% report loneliness (4.7% severe), and 12.9% have experienced poor mental health (Struijs, 2023). The TU Delft's My Wellness Check survey, initiated during COVID-19, indicates: - 80% of students expected the university to assist them in supporting their mental health. - 60% of students worry too much. - 54% of students indicated their stress levels are unsustainable. - high rates of depression, stress, low self-worth, poor sleep, and loneliness among students (Van der Maden et al., 2021).
Norway	**The Oslo School of Architecture and Design (AHO)** is a specialized professional education institution and research-based school, focusing on architecture, landscape architecture, and design. Annually, the school has approximately 650 students and is located on a single campus in Oslo, Norway. The five-year Master's of design program follows a studio-	Country-wide research in Norway on student wellbeing indicates: - 33.9% post-secondary students meet the formal criteria for a current mental disorder, with the most common being major depressive episodes and generalized anxiety disorder (Sivertsen & Johansen, 2023). - Severe mental health issues among Norwegian post-secondary students

	based model with a faculty-to-student ratio that encourages individual development and collaboration.	have steadily risen since 2010 (Sivertsen & Johansen, 2022). A survey by AHO Student Wellbeing Working Group in 2021 found: - 84% of students agree or strongly agree that students support each other in a way that contributes to a positive environment. - 38% of students agree or strongly agree that they understand the rationale for the feedback given in an evaluation situation.
Denmark	**Aalborg University (AAU)** is a young, multidisciplinary university with campuses in Aalborg, Copenhagen, and Esbjerg. In Copenhagen, it welcomes 700 new students annually and offers a Master's in Service Systems Design with 35 yearly enrolments. The program follows a problem-based learning approach, emphasizing user participation, social innovation, and sustainability.	- Mental illness and poor wellbeing are growing concerns in Denmark, with 15% of youth receiving a psychiatric diagnosis before 18 (Møller et al., 2023). - Despite political efforts, stress remains high—28% of 15-30-year-olds needed medical attention or sick leave for severe stress in 2022; the issue is most severe among older students, with 41% of those aged 27+ taking sick leave due to stress (Youth Wellbeing Council, 2022).

United Kingdom	**University of the Arts, London (UAL)** hosts a diverse community of over 2,400 postgraduate students across various disciplines, including art, design, screen, fashion, communication, media, and performing arts. The MA Service Design Course at the London College of Communication is designed to guide students through the principles and practice of Service Design, beginning with localised challenges and progressively expanding toward systemic, environmental, and future-oriented perspectives.	Country Level Data: - 57% of respondents self-reported a mental health issue, and 27% said they had a diagnosed mental health condition (Student Minds, 2022). - Relocation, academic and financial pressures, and lack of support networks are key factors in student mental health decline (Lewis & Bolton, 2023). University Level data**:** - 74% of students reported experiencing burnout, and 50% had seriously considered leaving their course (The Student Union UAL Mental Health Survey Results 2022-23)

Table 2. Geographical overview of our network of universities, programs, and available data on students' mental health and wellbeing.

Stories and well practices

Building on this background, we shared and discussed how our current wellbeing practices address the identified academic and design-specific stressors. As an initial exploration, each institution contributed one representative practice, outlining its intervention level, targeted stressors, participant scope, and assessment method. These practices are detailed below and mapped in Figure 7, illustrating their potential as structural examples for a new design education approach promoting mental health and wellbeing.

Team Building support (Polimi)
Level of Intervention: Program
Academic Stressors: Transition to university; Multicultural university environment
Design-specific stressors: Interpersonal conflict with team members
Participants: 80 students per year (40 Italian, 40 international)
Description: PSSD includes a one-week team-building module at the start of the program, led by a psychologist, aimed at developing teamwork, negotiation, conflict management, and leadership skills, while easing the transition into a new cultural and

educational context. Wellbeing surveys[1] conducted in 2023 and 2024 identified teamwork as a key source of stress throughout the two-year program. In response, program coordinators and studio teachers collaborated with the psychologist to extend and embed team-building tools and strategies. Last year, the psychologist trained studio faculty and teaching assistants in using tools such as the "teamwork passport" and "team agreement," and in monitoring team dynamics. These tools were also transferred to a shared Miro Board to support ongoing use and student reflection across both years.

Assessment: The second wellbeing survey showed an improvement in the mean score from 2.89 to 3.15 out of 5, though negative team dynamics remained the primary stressor. In 2025, the survey was not repeated due to the launch of an Ateneo-level mental health survey in 2024, for which aggregated data analysis is still pending.

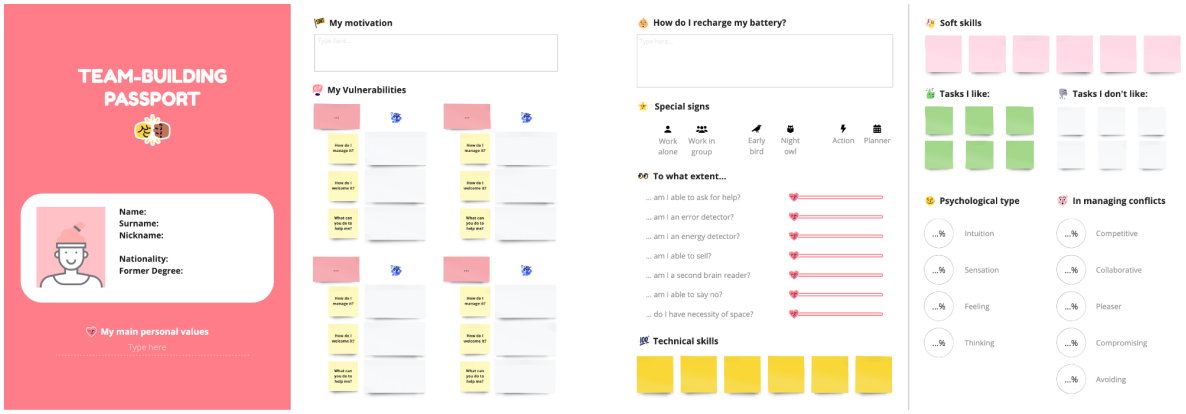


Figure 1. Template for the Team-building passport (source: work by Gioia Gabellieri).

Course Manuals and Workload Calculations (Aalto)

Level of intervention: Course

Academic Stressors: Study-work-life balance, Perceived workload

Design Specific stressors: Problem solution co-evolution

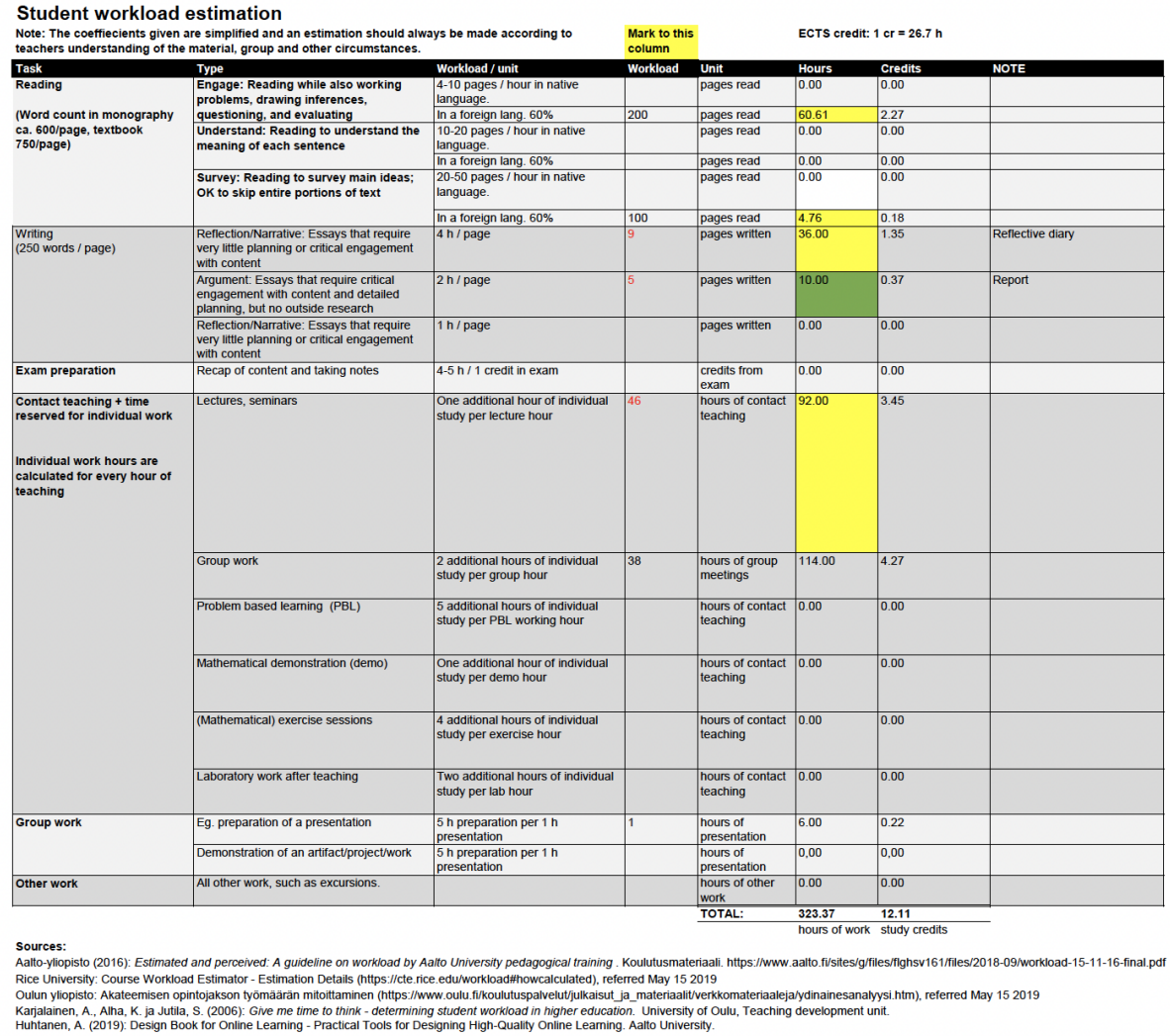
Participants: 25 students: ⅓ Finnish, and ⅔ international students

Description: At Aalto, a course syllabus is a mandatory document that outlines basic course information, learning outcomes, credits (ECTS), and assessment methods. A course manual provides an overview of all interconnected activities from the

[1] The survey was based on the Short Warwick- Edinburgh Mental Wellbeing Scale (SWEMWBS) 2024

perspective of student workload, including week-by-week individual and group tasks to help students plan their work accordingly. End-of-course surveys at Aalto Arts consistently show that students spend significantly more time on courses than expected. Offering a single document with all practical information in advance helps students organize and guide their project work, supporting a more balanced workload across studies, work, and life.

In project-based courses developed with external partners, students use a co-evolution approach to problem-solving, learning to balance the openness of a design brief with time constraints. Short courses may intensify perceived workload, especially affecting group dynamics. In planning, using standard time allocation models (Karjalainen et al., 2006) gives teachers a realistic view of feasibility and helps students develop project management practices that support a healthier study-work-life balance.



Student workload estimation

Note: The coeffiecients given are simplified and an estimation should always be made according to teachers understanding of the material, group and other circumstances.

Mark to this column

ECTS credit: 1 cr = 26.7 h

Task	Type	Workload / unit	Workload	Unit	Hours	Credits	NOTE
Reading	**Engage: Reading while also working problems, drawing inferences, questioning, and evaluating**	4-10 pages / hour in native language.		pages read	0.00	0.00	
(Word count in monography ca. 600/page, textbook 750/page)		In a foreign lang. 60%	200	pages read	60.61	2.27	
	Understand: Reading to understand the meaning of each sentence	10-20 pages / hour in native language.		pages read	0.00	0.00	
		In a foreign lang. 60%		pages read	0.00	0.00	
	Survey: Reading to survey main ideas; OK to skip entire portions of text	20-50 pages / hour in native language.		pages read	0.00	0.00	
		In a foreign lang. 60%	100	pages read	4.76	0.18	
Writing (250 words / page)	Reflection/Narrative: Essays that require very little planning or critical engagement with content	4 h / page	9	pages written	36.00	1.35	Reflective diary
	Argument: Essays that require critical engagement with content and detailed planning, but no outside research	2 h / page	5	pages written	10.00	0.37	Report
	Reflection/Narrative: Essays that require very little planning or critical engagement with content	1 h / page		pages written	0.00	0.00	
Exam preparation	Recap of content and taking notes	4-5 h / 1 credit in exam		credits from exam	0.00	0.00	
Contact teaching + time reserved for individual work **Individual work hours are calculated for every hour of teaching**	Lectures, seminars	One additional hour of individual study per lecture hour	46	hours of contact teaching	92.00	3.45	
	Group work	2 additional hours of individual study per group hour	38	hours of group meetings	114.00	4.27	
	Problem based learning (PBL)	5 additional hours of individual study per PBL working hour		hours of contact teaching	0.00	0.00	
	Mathematical demonstration (demo)	One additional hour of individual study per demo hour		hours of contact teaching	0.00	0.00	
	(Mathematical) exercise sessions	4 additional hours of individual study per exercise hour		hours of contact teaching	0.00	0.00	
	Laboratory work after teaching	Two additional hours of individual study per lab hour		hours of contact teaching	0.00	0.00	
Group work	Eg. preparation of a presentation	5 h preparation per 1 h presentation	1	hours of presentation	6.00	0.22	
	Demonstration of an artifact/project/work	5 h preparation per 1 h presentation		hours of presentation	0,00	0,00	
Other work	All other work, such as excursions.			hours of other work	0.00	0.00	
				TOTAL:	**323.37** hours of work	**12.11** study credits	

Sources:

Aalto-yliopisto (2016): *Estimated and perceived: A guideline on workload by Aalto University pedagogical training* . Koulutusmateriaali. https://www.aalto.fi/sites/g/files/flghsv161/files/2018-09/workload-15-11-16-final.pdf

Rice University: Course Workload Estimator - Estimation Details (https://cte.rice.edu/workload#howcalculated), referred May 15 2019

Oulun yliopisto: Akateemisen opintojakson työmäärän mitoittaminen (https://www.oulu.fi/koulutuspalvelut/julkaisut_ja_materiaalit/verkkomateriaaleja/ydinainesanalyysi.htm), referred May 15 2019

Karjalainen, A., Alha, K. ja Jutila, S. (2006): *Give me time to think - determining student workload in higher education.* University of Oulu, Teaching development unit.

Huhtanen, A. (2019): Design Book for Online Learning - Practical Tools for Designing High-Quality Online Learning. Aalto University.

Figure 2. Aalto workload estimation tool used by teachers in the course planning phase.

Assessment: A comparison of course surveys conducted before these implementations in 2019 and after in 2024 reveals a significant decrease in the percentage of students reporting excessive time spent on coursework, dropping from 31% to 4.8%. Additionally, in end-of-course qualitative feedback, students consistently praised the course's clear structure, supporting the enjoyment of their learning, and recommended that the course manual be adopted across all courses.

Resilience, Identity development, Reflection (TU Delft)

Level of Intervention: Program

Academic Stressors: Career uncertainty / Career anxiety

Design specific stressors: Uncertain and fluid professional identity, and Interpersonal conflict with project team members
Participants: 300 students from across three MSc programmes

Description: In 2024, the Faculty of Industrial Design Engineering instituted, for the first time, instruction-free weeks (Synergy Weeks) at the centre of each quarter, to provide time and space for students to engage in student and staff-initiated workshops for reflection, identity work, cross-cultural connection, and community building. Synergy weeks mark a significant structural and cultural change in the curriculum, moving away from the previous model of tightly packing content into each quarter and postponing reflection until after final submissions. One recent Synergy week featured a student-organized workshop, *Exploring Cross-cultural Tensions in Design*. A group of seven students formed a working group to explore how culture affects design team dynamics and offer peer advice to support intercultural learning (Figure 3). Advice on how different cultures approach designing was compiled to pass on to peers working in the course. The group plans to run a larger-scale version of the workshop during Synergy Week 3.5 and has collaborated with the Faculty's International Office to expand their efforts.

Assessment: A review of the previous MSc curriculum revealed a lack of structured reflection time. Reflection typically occurred after final submissions, when students were exhausted. The pandemic also raised concerns about student well-being and stress. A staff-led evaluation of recent reflection events showed that students value having dedicated time to pause, consolidate learning, connect with peers, catch up on work, and develop soft and hard skills.



Figure 3: Captured moments from Synergy 2.4.

Giving & Receiving Feedback Across Cultures (AHO)

Level: Program

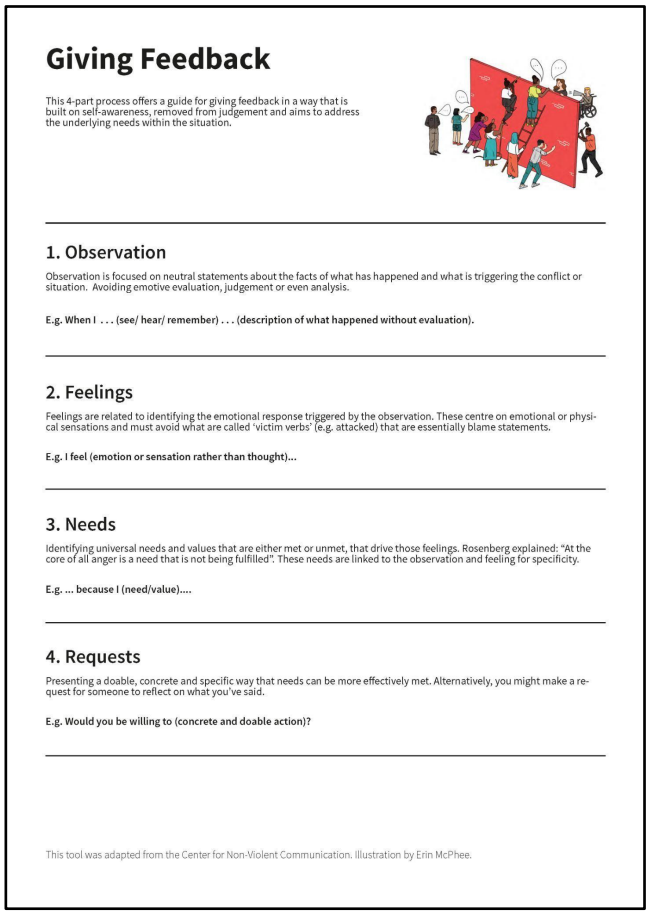
Academic stressors: Multi-cultural environment, career anxiety

Design-specific stressors: Dealing with criticism, interpersonal conflict

Participants: 40-60 students (approximately 90% Norwegian and 10% International students)

Description: To support the integration of students into the design master's program at AHO, a two-day orientation program has been established and has been running for the last 10 years. As part of this program, a half-day is dedicated to practicing giving and receiving feedback across cultures. To build an understanding of cultural differences and their implications, students are invited to share challenging past experiences navigating across cultures through a structured story-sharing and listening activity in triads with feelings and needs cards. Then, students are given fictitious situations and a structured framework for giving feedback (from the Center for Non-Violent Communication) and invited to practice and reflect on delivering feedback in this way based on the scenarios provided. Lastly, students are presented with common barriers to receiving feedback and provided with strategies for moving beyond these barriers in the feedback process. This collective activity at the beginning of the program sets a tone for mindful and respectful feedback, with an awareness of possible impacts across culture, and builds the students' capabilities and openness to giving and receiving direct feedback from each other.

Assessment: A verbal reflection on the activity was conducted at the end of the session, where students noted feeling more equipped to provide feedback to others and collaborate across cultures. At the end of the semester, students again highlighted the benefits of integrating these approaches in their end-of-year reflections. However, a systematic evaluation was not conducted.



Giving Feedback

This 4-part process offers a guide for giving feedback in a way that is built on self-awareness, removed from judgement and aims to address the underlying needs within the situation.

1. Observation

Observation is focused on neutral statements about the facts of what has happened and what is triggering the conflict or situation. Avoiding emotive evaluation, judgement or even analysis.

E.g. When I . . . (see/ hear/ remember) . . . (description of what happened without evaluation).

2. Feelings

Feelings are related to identifying the emotional response triggered by the observation. These centre on emotional or physical sensations and must avoid what are called 'victim verbs' (e.g. attacked) that are essentially blame statements.

E.g. I feel (emotion or sensation rather than thought)...

3. Needs

Identifying universal needs and values that are either met or unmet, that drive those feelings. Rosenberg explained: "At the core of all anger is a need that is not being fulfilled". These needs are linked to the observation and feeling for specificity.

E.g. ... because I (need/value)....

4. Requests

Presenting a doable, concrete and specific way that needs can be more effectively met. Alternatively, you might make a request for someone to reflect on what you've said.

E.g. Would you be willing to (concrete and doable action)?

This tool was adapted from the Center for Non-Violent Communication. Illustration by Erin McPhee.

Figure 4. Guide to giving feedback adapted from the Center for Non-Violent Communication.

Contemplative practice (AAU)

Level of intervention: Classroom

Academic Stressors: Academic performance, Perceived workload, Classroom competition

Design-specific Stressors: Feeling powerless in the face of systemic challenges

Participants: 32 students, 5 Danish and 27 internationals

Description: Recognizing the stress, ecological grief, and pervasive feelings of anxiety and uncertainty about the future among our students, we have begun exploring a pedagogy of tenderness and contemplative practices in some of our SSD classes. Tenderness, as brought into the classroom, welcomes silence, breath, movement, and turning inwards, makes space for imagination and emotions, and takes into account the students' whole selves (Barbezat & Bush, 2014). This pedagogy integrates contemplative elements, such as meditation, conscious breathing, yoga, deep listening, and reflective reading and writing into our classes.

Many students have expressed gratitude for these practices, describing a renewed sense of calm and peace, which encourages introspection and fosters a deeper connection to their inner selves (Neuhoff et al., 2022).
Assessment: Through the semester evaluation survey, the students provided feedback about the course in which this specific activity was offered: the evaluation of the particular class was very positive, with an explicit request from most of the students to integrate similar practices across the master's.



Figure 5: Captured moments from a contemplative exercise.

Enhancing Communication and Cultural Sensitivity through Collaboration and Teamwork (UAL)

Level of intervention: Course
Academic stressors: Multi-cultural environment, transition to university-level education in a new country, and classroom competition
Design-specific stressors*:* Communication barriers, adaptation to a new country, and a different creative environment, cultural Intelligence
Participants: 30 students (90% international students and 10% UK students)

Description: Despite early exposure to institutional wellbeing services, student engagement remains low (MASD informal student feedback 2023-24). This suggests the significance of embedding culturally responsive and creatively delivered wellbeing strategies that directly embed empathy, trust, and psychological safety into the curriculum. The *Ways of Working* (WOW) Unit, drawing on Green et al. (2020) and their work on adaptability in education, is strategically positioned as the first taught unit to establish these core values. It addresses common barriers in multicultural teams such as miscommunication, differing expectations, and uneven confidence, often intensified by linguistic and cultural differences. Through structured practices like active listening, empathy-based dialogue, and culturally sensitive communication, the WOW unit prepares students for more inclusive and meaningful engagement. Tutors and group leaders receive targeted guidance to cultivate team environments that encourage constructive disagreement while maintaining psychological safety. Moreover, the unit promotes emotional connection through academic and non-academic interactions, like one-to-one tutorials and informal community-building activities help foster trust and interpersonal ease beyond the classroom. Collaborative projects reinforce not only design competencies but also a deeper understanding of interdependence, shared ownership, and team accountability.

Assessment: For this paper, reflective essays, initially designed for unit assessment, were analyzed using Atlas.ti for thematic coding. While prominent themes included communication, conflict resolution, and role negotiation, students consistently referenced psychological safety, emotional trust, and stress management. Initially not intended as formal tools for assessing mental health outcomes, the qualitative data provided rich insights into students' affective experiences, serving as valid proxies for wellbeing (Geitz et al., 2024).



Figure 6. WoW Unit Final Presentations November 2023. MA Service Design London College of Communication, UAL. Lead Tutor: Veron Lai

Although these initiatives currently coexist with traditional teaching approaches and are supported by limited baseline data and follow-up assessments, they retrospectively demonstrate the potential of care-oriented pedagogies to address various stressors across different levels of design education, as illustrated in Figure 7.

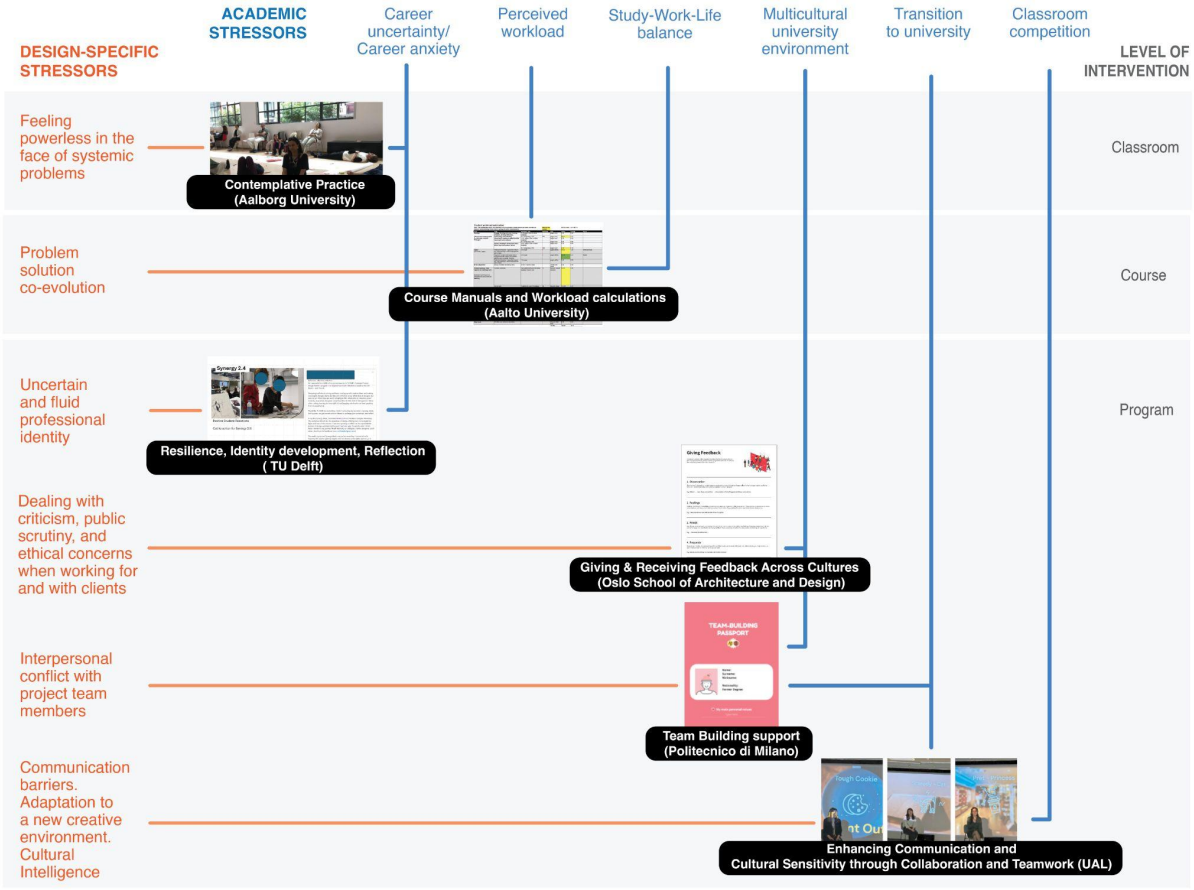


Figure 7. Visualization of the Well practices across academic and design-specific stressors.

Discussion

This paper highlights the urgent need to rethink design pedagogy, which contributes to the stressors faced by university design students. We advocate for inclusive teaching practices that can transform design education and support mental health and wellbeing. As faculty, we witness how unaddressed stressors hinder learning and place students in vulnerable situations. While these challenges are systemic, pedagogy and school-wide initiatives play a key role in mitigating them. By synthesizing key stressors from the literature, this paper offers a resource for educators and institutions to evaluate and strengthen support strategies.

Although based on a small sample of European design schools, our mapping reveals a heavy reliance on individual teacher initiative and a lack of specialized expertise at

the intersection of pedagogy and mental health. This highlights the need for institutionalized support through teacher training, stronger integration with university infrastructure, and involvement of mental health experts. We also emphasize the importance of evaluating impact and identifying conditions to scale effective practices.

This paper marks an initial step toward cross-institutional knowledge exchange, but more coordinated effort is needed to create supportive conditions. We call on design universities to collaborate, test, and evaluate new practices that address unmet stressors. Meaningful progress requires challenging traditional norms. As faculty, we must be willing to transform our practices—while also caring for our own wellbeing. To envision hopeful and healthy futures, we must build a movement of ambassadors within institutions and networks to reimagine design education through the lens of wellbeing.

We stress the need for increased structure and support, while balancing essential learning principles and fostering exploration. Though sensitive to mental health, we do not advocate eliminating uncertainty, which is core to discovery. We acknowledge our study's limitations and urge future teaching practices to consider students' existing mental health and prior experiences.

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